

Episode 53: Once Upon a Time... (34) – A Vivid World of Gods! *Tenjou-hen* *Uchuu Kouji* Part 2

Last week I went to three concerts. Man, this was definitely a first (laugh). When things pile up, they really pile up (laugh).

First was Oda Kazumasa's concert. As expected, a super major feel with a huge 10,000-person scale live show. Since it was at Yokohama Arena right by JR Shin-Yokohama Station, us adults naturally took the Tokaido Shinkansen from Tokyo Station (laugh). Round trip on the newest 700 series Nozomi trains (laugh).

Actually, I've been an Oda Kazumasa fan for 30 years since his Off Course days. I never imagined that he'd have such a breakthrough after turning 60 (bitter laugh). Oh no, I'm happy about it though (laugh).

Second was Matsuo Kazuhiko at a live house in Ebisu. He's one of the former Off Course members, and this was an intimate, homey 70-person limited live show. He's 9 years older than me with a quiet big-brother feel (laugh). For him, intimate live houses are better than big halls (laugh).

And third was Hitoto Yo. At Omiya Sonic City Main Hall in front of Omiya Station. This was a medium-scale 2,500-seat hall. This was my first time going to her concert, but man, she can sing! Much more solid delivery than the impression from CDs. Plus the live show was much more energetic (laugh)—a really fun concert.

Being in this business, what catches my attention at concerts are the visual direction of staging and lighting effects. Concert lighting is amazing! They combine various lights according to song order and style to create spaces. Not just the performing artist and stage, but they skillfully throw lighting into the audience seating too, creating unity throughout the entire hall. This is something that can't be fully conveyed just by

watching live DVDs. Light and colour. People doing anime should definitely make opportunities to go see concerts by their favourite artists!

Well then.

The OVA series *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* finally got moving.

The director was Imazawa Tetsuo. This was my first time working with Imazawa-san on this production. *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* led to me later participating in the theatrical work *COO: Come From a Distant Ocean* (遠い海から来たC O O).

All 13 episodes had storyboard & direction rotating among three people: Imazawa-san, Umezawa Yoshitoshi, and Yoshizawa Takao.

As I wrote before, I handled character colour design and colour direction for each episode. Though it was a 13-episode series, unlike TV it wasn't weekly delivery, so in principle I was entrusted with colour direction and inspection for all episodes. When you do character design, you naturally want to do colour direction and inspection too. Like the concurrent Toei Video OVAs I was participating in, during this period my work flow increasingly became "doing everything myself."

Now, for *Uchuu Kouji* character design.

The *Tenjou-hen Uchuu Kouji* original was a novel, but visuals like cover art were drawn by Inomata Mutsumi-san. So I remember referencing Inomata-san's art book (?) or something similar. I had also glimpsed the theatrical *Uchuu Kouji*, so that was somewhat referenced too...

But this *Uchuu Kouji* was the "Heaven Chapter." While episode 1 was set in the earthly realm of the capital (miyako) and Mount Kongou, from episode 2 onwards the setting becomes the heavenly realm, the world of gods. Yes, gods! "Asura King," "Four Heavenly Kings," "Fudou Myouou" and so on—the gods who successively appear before *Uchuu*

Kouji and others had no particular colour references, and most were colours I created and decided on with everyone as usual.

The common recognition among the director and everyone was "The heavenly realm must be a colourful, flashy world, surely." So in contrast to the earth realm with its subdued, low-saturation colours that could be taken as almost monochrome, both the art and character colours made the heavenly realm bright and gorgeous. And I thought of the gods in vivid, extremely colourful tones.

The appearing gods were basically Buddhist guardian deities. Considering the visuals of original Buddhist art, they are indeed extremely colourful. So I used the characteristics of STAC paints—the vivid cel paints that had tormented me until then—to my advantage, creating brilliant gods (laugh).

Another important point was "gold colour." First, a ship that flies through the sky called "Tenshousen" appears in the story, and it was supposed to be "blindingly golden." For things crossing to the heavenly realm, and the heavenly realm itself, I felt "gold colour" was quite a "key" in creating colours. So in the heavenly realm, I used "gold colour" quite extensively at key points for characters and props.

"Gold colour" comes out beautifully in photography. Especially since we were using film at the time, it was true transmitted light processing, and effects that captured light itself were dazzlingly beautiful. The brilliance of the golden clouds that welcome Princess Nayotake back to the heavenly realm in episode 1 is still entrancing when I watch it now (oh, but the colour flickering... sorry even now (sobbing)).

(Actually, I dug up a LaserDisc player from my parents' house this time. I watched it for the first time in about 10 years. Man, I was trying all sorts of things here and there, and the screen overflows with the feeling that I was working enjoyably, which is quite heartwarming (bitter laugh))

Episode 1 ended like that.

My reaction after watching the first print was a "smirk" (laugh). I had a premonition while making it, but this was "quite an interesting job I've encountered!" for me (laugh). I had a "hooked!" feeling. First I enjoyed myself, then got excited thinking "I can do the next episode and the one after that—everything myself!"

But after this, an unexpected situation was waiting for me.

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